Eventually, the lack of water began to weigh against the Harappans. Their carefully managed cities began to disintegrate and they began to migrate. This would not be the last time that cities in the subcontinent would suffer from the vagaries of too much or too little water. One can imagine long lines of bullock-carts, heavily laden with personal belongings, leaving their old villages and cities in search of a more secure future. The scene was replayed in 2010 when Pakistan was devastated by floods. In the north, the Harappans moved north-east to the Yamuna and Ganga. In Gujarat, the cities in Kutchh were abandoned in favour of new settlements in the Narmada and Tapti valleys to the south.[8] The late Harappan sites show a degree of cultural continuity but there is a clear shift towards smaller settlements. The old urban sophistication has clearly broken down. Thus ended India's first experience of urbanization.

## WHERE DID THE HARAPPANS GO?

The archaeological evidence suggests that they slowly drifted east and south, and that their culture and genes lived on in India. However, archeologists and historians disagree bitterly on this. Romila Thapar, an eminent historian, is of the opinion that the 'material culture shows no continuities'. [9] In contrast, B.B. Lal, a former Director General of the Archaeological Survey and one of India's most celebrated archaeologists, argues that 'many of the present day cultural traits are rooted in the Harappan Civilization.' [10]

We have already discussed the similarity between modern-day bullock carts and those used by the Harappans. However, B.B. Lal puts forward a formidable body of evidence that the Harappan legacy is not just visible in later Indian civilization but is present in everyday life to this day. Take for example, the 'namaste'—the common Indian way to show respect to both people and to the gods. There are several clay figurines from Harappan sites that show a person with palms held together in a namaste. There are even terracotta dolls of women with red vermilion on their foreheads. Is this the